

Characteristics of sequences

Sequences are identified by a pattern that is restated, two or more times in a row, with each repetition being a consistent distance higher, or lower, in pitch than its predecessor. Sequences are repeated at the same size interval, but the quality of the interval may change. Diatonic sequences generally use the notes in the given key signature, which may change the quality, but not the size of the interval. In pure sequences, the composer may employ altered whole steps to maintain exact interval content.



△ Sequence 2

Here each repetition begins one whole step, or major second, above the previous, except the last one, which is only a half step, or minor second, above. The contour is constant and the C major tonality is maintained.

This measure, as written, creates a sudden cadential motion to C# major. This is an awkward, unlikely key change.



△ Modified sequence 2

If the starting pitch were kept consistently on a major second, the last measure would start on an F#, not a note found in C major. The strong tonal center of the sequence would be lost.

The last two measures shown here provide an example of pure sequencing: each note in the last measure is exactly a major second higher than its equivalent in the previous.

LOOKING CLOSER

Using sequences

Composers of the Baroque and Classical eras used sequences to a high degree to create repetition and unity within their music. See if you can find the sequences that occur in this example. The sequence in the treble clef, or right hand, is a motif of downward running notes, sequenced at the interval up a minor, or major second. The sequence in the bass clef, or left hand, is an upward sixth motif that is sequenced up one scale degree.

▽ Mozart's *Piano Concerto in A Major*

This is an excerpt from the first movement, Allegro, of the *Piano Concerto No. 23*, K. 488 (1786).

